

Left (top to bottom) Silky Camembert, one of the world's most-copied cheeses; dairy cows in Normandy, France; turning Comté in Fort Saint Antoine cellars, home of Fromagerie Marcel Petite

Below (top to bottom) Traditionally dressed cheese porters load up at the Alkmaar cheese market in the Netherlands; artisanal cheeses on display on an Italian market stand



Les Routes du Comté

www.lesroutesducomte.com

Follow suggested itineraries or tailor your own driving tour along this route, and let local farmers demonstrate the care with which Comté is made and how good it is. Dairyman Jean François Marmier runs a herd of Montbeliarde cows, the ones most closely aligned with Comté, which visitors can help milk or feed for a more hands-on Alpine experience.

LOMBARDY, ITALY

Plump with natural beauty – rivers, lakes, mountains – as well as cities brimming with art and history, the kingdom of Lombardy is also rich in *formaggio*, with big hitters such as Gorgonzola, Grana Padano, and Taleggio.

Formaggi Galli

Piazza Wagner, Milan

Marco Galli's stand in Milan's huge Piazza Wagner food market specializes in Lombardy cheeses. Slow Food supporter Galli is known for sourcing exceptional Gorgonzola, some aged to mind-blowing maturity.

La Baita del Formaggio

Via Italia 42, Milan; www.labaitadelformaggio.it

This traditional cheese shop offers up a host of artisanal Italian cheeses. The Lariano Speziato, a soft cheese from the mountains surrounding Lake Como, is exclusive to the shop.

Rossi y Grassi

Via Ponte Vetere 4, Milan; www.rg.mi.it

In the classy Brera district, this top-quality gourmet food shop displays a tempting selection of Italian cheeses, including fruity Grana Padano and soft Taleggio, plus wines from Italy's greatest producers. There is another branch close by on Via Solferino.

THE NETHERLANDS

The Dutch have been making cheese since at least the 4th century, with Gouda and Edam now global favorites. Both towns are within easy striking distance of Amsterdam. Don't miss the legendary cheese carriers at the weekly summer markets.

Abraham Kef

Marnixstraat 192, Amsterdam; www.abrahamkef.nl

A little piece of France in central Amsterdam, this shop specializes in French as well as Dutch cheeses. Their philosophy is that good cheese is inseparable from good wine, and you can enjoy both in the shop's small dining area.

De Kaaskamer

Runstraat 7, Amsterdam; <http://kaaskamer.nl>

In the newly fashionable "Nine Streets" shopping area, this shop, with its floor-to-ceiling selection of cheeses – including organic Dutch offerings – is sure to keep cheese fans both happy and busy.

Kaashuis Tromp

Utrechtsestraat 90, Amsterdam; www.kaashuistromp.nl

Henk van Kol's "House of Cheese" has expanded into a small universe, with another three branches in Amsterdam and 10 more throughout the Netherlands. The flagship store, noted for its friendly service, is packed with Dutch cheeses of all kinds, including many from small-scale producers, along with 250 foreign cheeses.

TASMANIA, AUSTRALIA

With its pristine environment, clean, clear waters, lush green pastures, and fertile soil, Tasmania is home to many boutique dairy farms and artisan cheesemakers turning out creamy brie styles, full-bodied cheddar, and artisanal cow and goat cheeses.

Bruny Island Cheese Company

1807 Main Road, Great Bay, Bruny Island; www.brunyislandcheese.com.au

On this small island off Tasmania, famed for its fairy penguins and other wildlife, Nick Haddow churns out handmade cow, sheep, and goat cheeses, ranging from "Barney," a blue cheese, and the mild, Gruyère-like "C2" to specialties such as prosciutto-wrapped and olive oil-marinated cheeses. See and taste the cheeses being made, and don't miss their home-baked bread and homemade ice cream too.

King Island Diary

Currie, King Island; www.kidairy.com.au

Situated on another tranquil little island, Australia's best-known specialty cheese and dairy producer makes a range of creamy bries, pungent blues, and sharp aged cheddars, and has a tasting room in which they can be discovered.

Pyengana Cheese Factory

St. Columba Falls Road, Pyengana; +61 3 6373 6157

Australia's oldest cheddar is made following a method developed in the local cooperative in the 1890s by cheesemaker Jon Healey's grandfather. There are dairy and cheese factory tours by appointment, plus cheese sales in The Factory Shop.